Htut 2015). The USDP government did initiate a large number of reforms, ranging from the peace process, expansion of media freedom to reforms in economic and administrative policies (Pedersen 2015; Tin Maung Maung Than 2014). While there were initial positive reactions to these reforms, none of the main problems relevant to people's everyday lives abated. More importantly, the USDP government was unable to address the corruption, cronyism, and associated conspicuous wealth of its former and current members. Impunity of illicit businesses thriving in Myanmar with the alleged blessing of the retired or existing military and government officials sustained the public distrust of the previous military government and the military-backed USDP administration. This failure led the general public to view the USDP as morally bankrupt. Despite some positive views on the presidency of U Thein Sein, the USDP as a whole did not seem to Myanmar's general public to have any moral authority to take the country forward, remove injustices, and resolve socio-economic problems. Therefore, when the Buddhist-nationalist leaders urged Myanmar's Buddhist majority to back the USDP in the interest of morality, their call contradicted the popular understanding of the USDP as lacking such moral authority. The USDP, even under the relatively popular Thein Sein, was not a viable alternative to the NLD. The NLD's overall victory indicated "most voters' desire for overall political change [being] ranked higher than their concerns about religious issues" (Walton 2015).

In Rakhine State, the ANP offered an alternative to the NLD along ethno-nationalist and religious lines, and in a context that did not exist in most other parts of Myanmar. Rakhine ethno-nationalism provided the ANP with an alternative electoral platform based on Rakhine ethnicity and their communal concerns. However, if we consider the ANP case simply as an exception to the national trend, we run the risk of under-emphasizing the roles that ethnicity and religion continue to play in Myanmar politics more generally, and miss the complexity of ethnicity in the seemingly homogeneous Rakhine community. Over-emphasis on ethnicity and Buddhist nationalism before the election resulted in expectations of their influence that were not well founded, but the post-election wisdom on Myanmar should not simply discount them. Both religion and ethnicity remain salient to Myanmar politics, not only in Rakhine State but in other parts of the country as well.

The electoral strength of the ANP and USDP in Rakhine's southern townships could be an indication of the communal concerns that MaBaTha